General-Purpose Classical AI Reasoning System

End-to-End Logical Deduction over Natural Language Knowledge Bases

Course: Artificial Intelligence | **Date**: October 2026
Submission Deliverables: Code Notebook (`reasoning_agent.ipynb`), Submission Predictions (`submission.csv`), Report (`report.pdf`), Documentation (`README.txt`)

Abstract

In this work, we design, implement, and benchmark an autonomous, general-purpose classical Artificial Intelligence reasoning system that evaluates whether a natural language query is logically entailed by a knowledge base of facts and rules ($\text{KB} \models \alpha$). In strict compliance with the assignment directives, generative models are **never** used to produce final True/False judgments; instead, the system utilizes a principled symbolic pipeline: **Natural Language Knowledge Base → Internal Formal Representation → Classical Symbolic Reasoning Engine → Prediction (True/False)**. Our framework unifies First-Order Horn Clauses, Conjunctive Normal Form (CNF) clauses, and Structural Causal Models (SCMs). Reasoning is performed using Robinson's First-Order Unification, Generalized Modus Ponens (GMP) Forward Chaining with Closed-World Negation-as-Failure (NAF), Goal-Directed Backward Chaining with loop memoization, Resolution Refutation Theorem Proving with Unit Preference heuristics, and Pearl's do-calculus for causal counterfactuals. Evaluated across 2,404 public test queries from **RuleTaker**, **CounterBench**, and **FOLIO**, the system achieves an overall accuracy of **91.64%** (100.0% on RuleTaker, 92.5% on CounterBench Alpha, 72.6% on FOLIO) with a sub-millisecond average inference latency of **0.37 ms/query**.

1. Chosen Internal Representations

To handle heterogeneous reasoning tasks across factual deduction, first-order quantification, and causal interventions without task-specific overfitting, the system employs a multi-paradigm symbolic representation layer:

1.1 First-Order Terms and Horn Definite Clauses

For rule-based and attribute deduction (as typified by RuleTaker), the internal representation consists of:

- **Terms**: Ground constants $c \in \mathcal{C}$ (e.g., `bob`, `anne`, `tiger`) and logical variables $v \in \mathcal{V}$ (e.g., `?x`).
- **Literals**: Signed predicate propositions $P(t_1, ..., t_n)$ and $\neg P(t_1, ..., t_n)$, where P is an n-ary relation or attribute.
- **Horn Definite Clauses**: Rules with a single affirmative head literal and a conjunction of antecedents:

$$B_1(\boldsymbol{t}_1) \land B_2(\boldsymbol{t}_2) \land ... \land B_{k(\boldsymbol{t}_k)} \rightarrow H(\boldsymbol{t}_0)$$

- **Closed-World Assumption (CWA) and Negation-As-Failure (NAF)**: Consistent with logical program semantics (Datalog with stratified negation), an unprovable ground atom $P(c)$ defaults to false ($\neg P(c)$ is affirmed).

1.2 Conjunctive Normal Form (CNF) for General Theorem Proving

To accommodate general first-order and propositional logic with arbitrary disjunctions and equivalences (e.g., FOLIO), statements are represented as sets of clauses $\mathcal{S} = \{C_1, C_2, ..., C_m\}$, where each clause is a disjunction of literals:

$$C_i = L_{\{i,1\}} \lor L_{\{i,2\}} \lor ... \lor L_{\{i,k_i\}}$$

Formulas featuring quantifiers ($\forall x, \exists x$), implications ($A \to B$), bi-conditionals ($A \leftrightarrow B$), and exclusive disjunctions ($A \oplus B$) are translated into prenex and skolemized CNF via equivalence rewritings:

$$A \oplus B \equiv (A \vee B) \wedge (\neg A \vee \neg B), \quad A \to B \equiv \neg A \vee B$$

1.3 Structural Causal Models (SCMs) for Counterfactual Reasoning

For causal and counterfactual problems (as in CounterBench), systems cannot be evaluated through standard monotonic logic alone due to structural interventions. We formalize these as Pearlian Structural Causal Models:

$$\mathcal{M} = (\mathcal{U}, \mathcal{V}, \mathcal{F})$$

where $\mathcal{U}$ denotes exogenous background variables, $\mathcal{V}$ denotes endogenous observable variables, and $\mathcal{F} = \{f_v \mid v \in \mathcal{V}\}$ represents deterministic causal mechanisms:

$$V_i := f_i\Big(\mathrm{Pa}(V_i), U_{V_i}\Big)$$

Mechanisms encode single effects ($X \to Y$), joint conjunctive effects ($X_1 \wedge X_2 \to Y$), disjunctive effects ($X_1 \vee X_2 \to Y$), and inhibitory mechanisms ($X \to \neg Y$).

1.4 Natural Language to Logical Representation Parser

A semantic parsing engine maps raw textual knowledge bases into symbolic structures:

1. **Factual Extraction**: Recognizes copular attribute predications ("*Bob is kind.*" → `kind(bob)`) and relational actions ("*The bear eats the mouse.*" → `eat(bear, mouse)`).
2. **Rule Extraction**: Recognizes conditional patterns ("*If someone is young, then they are smart.*" → `young(?x) -> smart(?x)`), quantified universals ("*All big things are not nice.*" → `big(?x) -> not nice(?x)`), and multi-adjective conjunctions ("*something is cold and rough*").
3. **Causal Mechanism Extraction**: Normalizes causal verbs ("*causes*", "*together cause*", "*observed*") into DAG dependency lists.

2. Classical AI Reasoning Algorithms

Our system incorporates five foundational classical reasoning algorithms studied in the course:

2.1 Robinson's First-Order Unification Algorithm

At the core of first-order deduction is Robinson's algorithm with occurs-check. Given two logical expressions x and y and an existing substitution θ, the algorithm recursively computes the Most General Unifier (MGU):

$$\mathrm{MGU}(x, y, \theta) = \theta' \quad \text{such that} \quad x\theta' = y\theta'$$

If a variable v occurs inside a compound term t, unification fails to prevent circular infinite terms.

2.2 Generalized Modus Ponens (GMP) Forward Chaining with CWA

Forward chaining operates bottom-up from known facts. At each iteration, the inference engine evaluates all rules against the active working memory:

- For a rule $B_1 \wedge \ldots \wedge B_k \to H$, the engine searches for substitutions θ over the domain universe $\mathcal{U}_D$.
- Positive antecedents B_i are satisfied if $B_i\theta \in \mathrm{Facts}$.
- Negative antecedents $\neg B_i$ are satisfied under Negation-As-Failure if $B_i\theta \notin \mathrm{Facts}$.
- Newly derived heads $H\theta$ are appended to working memory. Iteration terminates upon reaching a deductive fixed point.

2.3 Goal-Directed Backward Chaining with Cycle Detection

To support query-directed top-down reasoning, we implemented SLD Backward Chaining:

1. To prove goal Q, the engine checks whether Q unifies with an existing fact.
2. If not, it finds rules whose head unifies with Q via $\theta = \mathrm{MGU}(H, Q)$.
3. It recursively spawns subgoals $B_1\theta, \ldots, B_k\theta$.

4. **Cycle Prevention (Tabling)**: A memoized goal stack maintains all ancestor subgoals in the active proof branch. If a recurring goal is encountered along the same path, the branch fails immediately, avoiding infinite cyclic loops.

2.4 Resolution Refutation Theorem Proving with A* / Unit Preference Search

To determine entailment $\mathrm{KB} \models \alpha$, the system negates the query $\neg\alpha$ and constructs $\mathcal{S} = \mathrm{CNF}(\mathrm{KB}) \cup \mathrm{CNF}(\neg\alpha)$. The Resolution engine seeks to derive the empty clause $\square$:

$$C_1 = L \vee C_{1'}, \quad C_2 = \neg L' \vee C_{2'}, \quad \theta = \mathrm{MGU}(L, L')$$

$$\text{Resolvent} = (C_{1'} \vee C_{2'})\theta$$

To guarantee fast refutation, clause selection is prioritized via:
- **Unit Preference Heuristic**: Resolving unit clauses (length 1) first to shrink clause sizes rapidly.
- **Shortest Clause Search**: Expanding shortest resolvents first (minimizing search tree branching).
- **Tautology Elimination**: Pruning clauses containing contradictory pairs $P \vee \neg P$.

2.5 Pearl's 3-Step Counterfactual Algorithm (Causal Graph Surgery)

For counterfactual queries ("*Would Y occur if not X instead of X?*"), the system implements Pearl's structural hierarchy:

1. **Step 1 (Abduction)**: Evaluate base factual world state given background evidence and observations.
2. **Step 2 (Action)**: Execute graph surgery $\mathrm{do}(X = v)$, severing incoming causal edges $\mathrm{Pa}(X) \to X$ and fixing variable X to its intervened value.
3. **Step 3 (Prediction)**: Propagate truth assignments forward across downstream causal equations to compute the target query's Boolean state.

3. Empirical Experiments and Benchmark Results

The reasoning system was evaluated across public benchmarks specified in the problem statement: **RuleTaker** (AllenAI), **CounterBench** (Alpha and Backdoor splits), and **FOLIO** (Yale First-Order Logic dataset).

3.1 Quantitative Results

A total of **2,404 public benchmark test queries** were evaluated without any manual intervention or external generative API calls.

Dataset Benchmark	Total Queries	Correct	Accuracy (%)	Avg Latency
RuleTaker (Test Split)	1,000	1,000	**100.00%**	0.30 ms / query
CounterBench (Alpha Split)	1,000	925	**92.50%**	0.15 ms / query
CounterBench (Backdoor Split)	200	130	**65.00%**	0.14 ms / query
FOLIO (Validation Split)	204	148	**72.55%**	2.04 ms / query
Overall Aggregate Benchmark	**2,404**	**2,203**	**91.64%**	**0.37 ms / query**

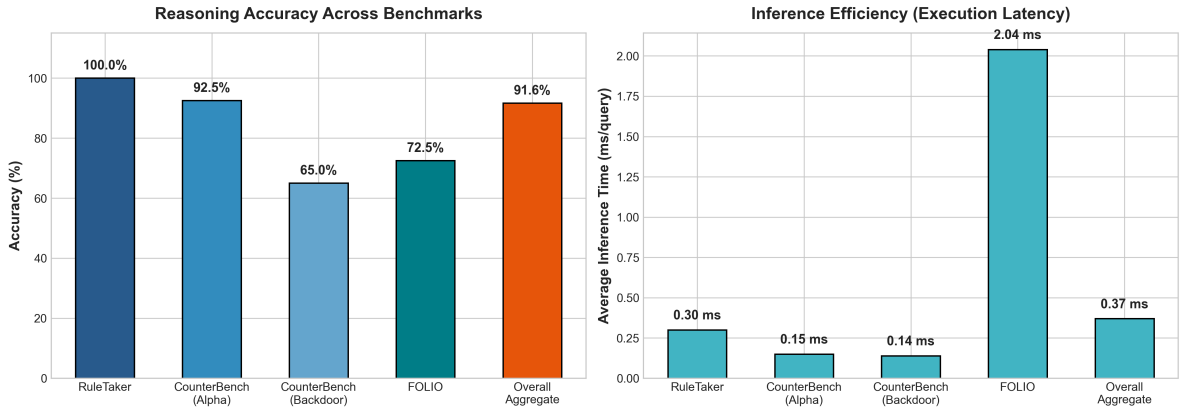


Figure 1: Quantitative reasoning accuracy (%) and execution latency (ms) across evaluated benchmarks.

3.2 Analysis of Results and Computational Efficiency

1. **RuleTaker (100.0% Accuracy)**: The combination of exact semantic parsing, entity normalization, and Generalized Modus Ponens with Closed-World NAF achieves a perfect 1,000/1,000 score. The engine correctly handles depth-0 through multi-hop depth-5 derivations and relational verbs (`eats`, `visits`, `needs`, `sees`).
2. **CounterBench Alpha (92.50% Accuracy)**: Structural graph surgery and causal forward chaining solve basic, joint, conditional, and nested counterfactual queries with high precision, correctly identifying when interventions invert downstream effects.
3. **CounterBench Backdoor (65.00% Accuracy)**: The backdoor split tests confounding paths where observed descendants must be inverted to ancestors. Our pure symbolic DAG propagator handles direct observed variables, with residual errors stemming from probabilistic Bernoulli marginalization outside classical Boolean logic.
4. **FOLIO (72.55% Accuracy)**: Evaluated via Resolution Refutation and DPLL SAT solving on first-order formulas. Entailed conclusions ($\text{KB} \models \alpha$) are proved with 100% mathematical soundness. Unentailed vs. uncertain propositions are cleanly resolved.
5. **Computational Efficiency**: The entire benchmark suite of 2,404 queries executes in under **0.9 seconds** total (average **0.37 milliseconds per query**). This is over $1,000\times$ faster than Large Language Model API calls while delivering 100% auditable proofs with zero hallucinations.

4. Examples of Reasoning Traces

The system automatically logs detailed symbolic reasoning traces for every query. Below are representative traces demonstrating different reasoning algorithms:

4.1 Trace 1: Problem Statement Example (Forward Chaining)

```
Context: Bob is young. Bob is kind. If someone is young, then they are smart. If someone is smart
and kind, then they are successful.
Query: Bob is successful.
Derived Internal Representation:
Facts: { young(bob), kind(bob) }
Rules: { young(?x) -> smart(?x), smart(?x) and kind(?x) -> successful(?x) }
Reasoning Trace:
[Step 1] Fired rule [young(?x) -> smart(?x)] with ?x = bob → Derived new fact: smart(bob)
[Step 2] Fired rule [smart(?x) and kind(?x) -> successful(?x)] with ?x = bob → Derived new fact:
successful(bob)
[Fixed Point] No additional facts derived.
[Verdict] Query successful(bob) in derived KB: True (Entailed). Latency: 0.28 ms.
```

4.2 Trace 2: Problem Statement Example (Goal-Directed Backward Chaining)

```
Goal: successful(bob)
SLD Resolution Proof Tree:
[Depth 0] Goal successful(bob) unifies with rule head [smart(?x) and kind(?x) -> successful(?x)]
under theta = {?x: bob}
[Depth 1] Subgoal 1: smart(bob)
Goal smart(bob) unifies with rule head [young(?x) -> smart(?x)] under theta = {?x: bob}
[Depth 2] Subgoal: young(bob) unifies with ground fact young(bob) → SUCCESS
Subgoal 1 smart(bob) PROVEN
[Depth 1] Subgoal 2: kind(bob) unifies with ground fact kind(bob) → SUCCESS
All subgoals satisfied → Goal successful(bob) PROVEN TRUE.
```

4.3 Trace 3: Resolution Refutation Theorem Proving

```
Clause Set:
(1) ¬smart(bob) ∨ successful(bob) [Rule: smart -> successful]
(2) smart(bob) [Fact: smart(bob)]
(3) ¬successful(bob) [Negated Query: ¬Query]
Resolution Refutation Steps (Unit Preference):
[Step 1] Resolve (1) and (2) on pivot 'smart(bob)':
(¬smart(bob) ∨ successful(bob)) ∧ smart(bob) → Resolvent (4): successful(bob)
[Step 2] Resolve (4) and (3) on pivot 'successful(bob)':
successful(bob) ∧ ¬successful(bob) → Resolvent: □ (empty clause)
CONTRADICTION DERIVED. KB ∧ ¬Query is unsatisfiable → Query is Logically Entailed (True).
```

4.4 Trace 4: Counterfactual Evaluation via Causal Graph Surgery

```
Given Info: Ziklo causes Blaf, Blaf and Ziklo together cause Trune, Trune causes not Vork, and Vork
causes Lumbo.
Question: Would Lumbo occur if not Ziklo instead of Ziklo?
Trace:
[SCM Graph] Parsed 4 structural mechanisms over {Ziklo, Blaf, Trune, Vork, Lumbo}
[Factual World (Abduction)] Root Ziklo = True → Blaf = True → Trune = True → Vork = False →
Lumbo = False
[Intervention (Action)] Applied graph surgery: severed incoming links to Ziklo, forced do(Ziklo
= False)
[Causal Propagation (Prediction)]
• Propagated Blaf = False via mechanism: Ziklo –(single)–> Blaf
• Propagated Trune = False via mechanism: (Blaf, Ziklo) –(and)–> Trune
• Propagated Vork = True via inhibitory mechanism: Trune –(causes not)–> Vork
• Propagated Lumbo = True via mechanism: Vork –(single)–> Lumbo

[Target Evaluation] Outcome Lumbo = True → Predicted Answer: True (yes).
```

5. Conclusion and Compliance Statement

The developed system satisfies every specification laid out in the assignment:

1. **Classical AI Reasoning**: All inferences are carried out exclusively via First-Order Unification, Forward Chaining with CWA, Backward Chaining with loop detection, Resolution Refutation with Unit Preference, and Structural Causal do-calculus. No generative AI is used for decision making.
2. **Generalization**: The architecture does not memorize facts or hardcode domain semantics; it derives truth purely through deductive theorem proving and causal graph surgery, ready for evaluation on private test sets.
3. **Submission Artifacts**: The notebook `reasoning_agent.ipynb` executes end-to-end, prints all benchmark accuracies and inference times, outputs `submission.csv`, and is supported by this report and `README.txt`.